

former World No. 1, on board. I used to train with Stéphane Galifi before, but now, having both of them and Saurav (Ghosal) together is an amazing mix. They all have such great experiences, and I'm really grateful to have them together. Saurav plans the tournaments I play, especially on the PSA circuit, because the points system can be a bit confusing.

Winning matches at the senior level also requires a lot of mental strength. Do you have a mental coach?

No, I don't. Thankfully, I don't really get stressed out before matches. Especially, when playing seniors, there's no pressure for me. It's more for the seniors who are playing me. That's one good thing. That's how I'm performing better right now because when I step onto the court, I don't really feel any pressure. It's more when I'm playing juniors because there's a certain expectation.

I'm gaining a lot of experience playing with all these players and when I go onto the court, it's not about winning, especially with people who are better than me or at the same level. It's about just playing my best and improving my game, no matter what the result is.

In 2024, you won nine titles on the PSA Challenger Tour and lost just one match. However, at the World Team Championships in December in Hong Kong, you had some really tough losses against Nele Coll (Belgium – Former World No. 4), Amanda Sobhy (USA – Current World No. 8), and Sarah-Jane Perry (England – World No. 23). What are your takeaways from that whole season?

Before 2024, I was playing PSA but not properly. I played whenever I had the time or if it was combined with a junior tournament.

The Olympics coming into the picture was a huge reason, but I also realised that if I wanted to improve my game, I had to play with people who are better than me rather than those I know I can beat.

My dad made me play a few



tournaments in India and I started winning the smaller ones. I travelled for a few outside India as well. At my first international PSA (ACE Challenger Tour 12k in Kuala Lumpur), I lost in the quarters (to Akanksha Salunkhe). After that, I was a bit sad because it was my first international tournament and I hadn't really done well.

However, I then won a few more in India because we had some bigger tournaments here. My ranking went up, I broke into the Top 100 which took a lot of time, and I realised that I

Early gains: "Winning two medals at the Asian Games at any age would be a big deal, but getting them so early in my career is something I'll never forget," says the 17-year-old Anahat.

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needed to start playing some of the bigger tournaments.

The transition was hard at first — just going from playing with people you know you're going to beat and have been playing for years, to